Hinduism

SOME SPECIAL CHARACTERISTICS

Hinduism stands for the religious ideas and practices of the Hindus in India, but the term "Hindu" itself is given by foreigners to the inhabitants of India. The religion of the Hindus in their own language is called *Sanātan Dharma,* meaning literally the "eternal religion." This religion is different from the other great religions of the world because it was not founded by any single prophet or son of God. It is the name for the dominant religious and moral thoughts of all the persons who have lived in India from almost prehistoric times to the present. These thoughts are preserved in what are called the authoritative texts, *Śruti,* or whatever has been "heard" from the elders. Technically, these texts are called the Vedas, the Brāhamaṇas, and the Āranyakas. More or less the same ideas are popularly expressed in the epics of the *Rāmāyana* and the *Mahābhārata,* the *Bhagavad-Gītā,* the semi-historical books of tales and legends of the ancient times, called the Purāṇas, which are called the *Smṛtis,* or "remembered" ones. Hinduism is claimed by its adherents to be a universal religion for man in general, for all times, and not for the Hindus alone.

Another feature of Hinduism is that, in spite of its being claimed as an eternal and an ever-present religion, it has no desire to propagate its religion to the followers of other religions. It is thus one of the most non-missionary and non-proselytizing religions in the world, though, by the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, attempts were made by the Ārya Samāja, a reformist sect of the Sanātan Dharma, to take the non-Hindus converted to Christianity and Islam back into the fold of Hinduism. But that attempt has been given up. Anyone can become a Hindu or may call himself a Hindu without any Hindu wanting him to become a Hindu. Hinduism believes that since all great religions recommend